



Notes from the Whiteboard -

Ways of Working

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Chapter 1: Ways of Working

The Room Where Nothing Was Wrong

I sat in yet another check-in. It was the third that week.

Eight people around the table. Five minutes in and it was over. Nobody had mentioned a single problem. The board looked the same as last time. And yet everyone was smiling politely, as if this was exactly what was supposed to happen.

Afterwards I asked one of the Scrum Masters what was actually happening in those meetings. She shrugged. “They don’t know what to use them for. It’s something the manager said they should have.”

That was when it landed. Five minutes. Eight people. No problems. And yet we all left the room knowing something was wrong.

Nobody had designed it that way. It had just become the safer option.

What the Silence Was Saying

The organisation had more than thirty teams and over five hundred people. On paper, things were moving. Sprints were running. Events were happening. The language of collaboration was everywhere.

The first time I sat with a team and asked what was actually making their week harder, the room went quiet. Not the quiet of people thinking. The quiet of people calculating. People weren't sharing what was actually hard. Risks were being absorbed quietly rather than raised openly. When something slipped, the conversation turned to who was responsible rather than what had gone wrong.

It wasn't cynicism. Most people genuinely wanted to do good work. They wanted to deliver something real, on time, with quality that meant something. But they had learned, gradually and without anyone deciding it, that honesty had consequences. So they managed downward instead of solving upward.

The official story was that everyone had it under control. That was the first sign something was wrong.

I started to see the same pattern across teams that looked nothing alike. A team with no goal strong enough to make collaboration feel necessary. A team that was productive on paper but had no shared sense of what they were trying to become together.

Different symptoms. The same root cause. The Ways of Working weren't broken because the processes were missing. They were broken because nothing in the system made it safe to say what was actually true.

The Vocabulary for What I Saw

Patrick Lencioni describes trust as the foundation of everything a team does. Not trust as a feeling, but as a behaviour. The willingness to be vulnerable. To say "I don't know", "I was wrong", or "I need help" without calculating the risk first.

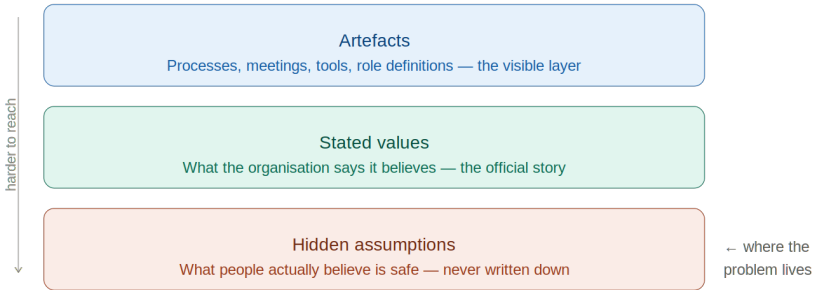
When that foundation is missing, teams don't collapse. They adapt. They become careful. They learn to present progress rather than reality, and to protect themselves rather than solve together. Lencioni calls this the first and most consequential dysfunction, because everything else is built on top of it.

Stephen Covey adds a structural dimension to this. Trust isn't just something people feel towards each other. It's something that gets built or eroded through systems and signals. When an organisation consistently rewards the appearance of control over honest disclosure, it teaches people what's safe. Not through policy. Through pattern.

What I was seeing across those teams wasn't a training problem or a tooling problem. It was a signal problem. The Ways of Working in place were sending a clear message: perform competence, hide difficulty, manage the narrative. Nobody had written that message down. But everyone had read it.

Edgar Schein's work on organisational culture adds a useful frame here. He describes culture in three layers: the artefacts you can see, the values an organisation claims to hold, and the deeper assumptions that nobody has written down but everyone acts on. The processes I was looking at, the check-ins, the boards, the role definitions, were artefacts. But the problem wasn't in the artefacts. It was in the layer underneath. The unspoken assumption that difficulty was a sign of failure, and that failure was something to manage

quietly rather than solve openly. You can redesign the artefacts. That's the easy part. The harder work is getting to what people actually believe is safe.



Timothy Clark's work on psychological safety adds a useful layer here. Safety doesn't start with whether people feel comfortable speaking up. It starts earlier, with whether people believe they have something worth contributing. A team that never gets to shape the work will eventually stop trying. Not dramatically. Just quietly, one refinement at a time.

A Ways of Working isn't neutral. It either creates the conditions for honesty, or it makes honesty feel like a risk not worth taking.

Starting Where the Work Actually Happened

The temptation was to start with the framework. Build the guide, define the roles, run the workshops. I nearly did. A few people expected that. A structured plan, a timeline, a set of deliverables. It would have been easier to present. Instead, I started where the work actually happened. I visited teams. Not to audit, but to listen. I asked people what made their week harder than it needed to be. What they wished someone would just decide. What they avoided bringing up in meetings.

The answers were consistent enough to act on.

The first thing we built was a team working guide. I drove the process, but the people closest to the work shaped what went into it. A practical reference that helped teams understand how to connect internally and with the teams around them. How to run their events in a way that served the work rather than the calendar. How to raise a blocker without it becoming a political conversation.

Alongside that, I set up a Community of Practice for Scrum Masters. A space where the people responsible for supporting teams could compare what they were seeing, test ideas, and build a shared language. One of the quieter problems was that the same role meant different things in different parts of the organisation. Two Scrum Masters could attend the same event and leave with entirely different understandings of what their job was.

The second strand of work was role clarity. I coordinated a process that started with interviews, to find the real baseline. Not what people thought their role was supposed to be, but what they were actually doing, what they were being held to, and where the edges were unclear. Then workshops to surface the gaps collectively. The people I interviewed

became part of identifying the problems. Then one-pagers. A single page per role that gave people clarity on what was expected, where their responsibilities ended, and what growth in the role could look like.

The one-pagers weren't a finish line. They were a starting point for a conversation that most teams had never had.

Both strands were connected by the same logic. If people don't have the language, the structure, or the safety to be honest about what's hard, no amount of process will fix it. The work wasn't about adding more process. It was about removing the friction that made honesty feel costly.

What Moved and What Didn't

The change didn't happen overnight, and I won't pretend it did.

For most of the organisation, this was a first step. Not a transformation. A baseline that hadn't existed before. Shared language. Clearer roles. A Community of Practice that gave Scrum Masters a peer group rather than a training programme. Not everyone experienced the same results, and some of the work won't show its value for a while yet.

But where we worked directly with individual teams, the picture was different. When I sat with a team, asked the right questions, and helped them name what was actually hard, things moved quickly. Blockers surfaced. Conversations that had been avoided started happening. The gap between the official story and the real one got smaller.

That distinction mattered. The structural work, the guides, the one-pagers, the role clarity process, created the conditions. But conditions alone don't change behaviour.

What changed behaviour was someone being present enough to make honesty feel worth the risk.

The teams that shifted fastest weren't the ones with the best processes. They were the ones where someone had made it safe to say what was true.

What I'd Do Differently

If I did this again, I'd spend less time on the structural work and more time with individual teams earlier.

The guides and one-pagers were necessary. They gave people something to point to, a shared reference that hadn't existed before. But I noticed that the structural work could become a way of feeling productive without getting close to the actual problem. It's easier to design a document than to sit with a team that has learned not to trust the system around them.

The interviews were the most valuable part of the role clarity process. Not because of what they produced, but because of what people said when someone finally asked.

That should have started sooner, and it should have been more of the work, not a step towards something else.

I started the Community of Practice early, and that was the right call. But we didn't have the mandate to match it. Most Scrum Masters were doing the role at ten to twenty percent of their time. The organisation valued the title without protecting the capacity. So I had people trying to support teams, attend a Community of Practice, and build shared practice, in the gaps between everything else they were responsible for. It limited what the CoP could actually become.

The hardest thing to admit is that the people who needed the work most were sometimes the hardest to reach. The teams that were most closed off, most practiced at performing competence, were the ones where direct engagement mattered most. And those were often the teams where getting access took the longest.

You can build the right conditions. But you can't shortcut the trust.

A question to take with you:

What would your teams say about your Ways of Working, if the answer was genuinely safe to give?